‘David, it’s terrible how it’s happened but we love you. I know how down you are. But we’re here. We’ll be happy when you’re home, Brooklyn and me.’

Victoria was right. She knew how much I’d wanted to make the final. That’s all she wanted for England too. But now it wasn’t going to happen, we had to see things as they were. My wife was seven months pregnant. She was missing me. My son was missing me. And I was missing them both. I’d rather have been staying in Japan but the thought of going back to England and my family was the one thing that lifted me on the way back to the hotel. We said goodbye. I said I’d see them the next day.

Back at the England team hotel, the Japanese were still out in force to welcome us back: they’d stuck with us just like our own fans. Inside, there were family and friends standing at the top of this long staircase that swept up on two sides. As the players made their way up the steps, there was applause. Mum and Dad were there. *Don’t start crying here.*

I hugged my parents, and nodded to one or two other people. I couldn’t speak to anyone. What was there to say? I just walked straight on through reception and up to my room. Quiet, lifeless, save for the low hum of the air-conditioning. I closed the door on the afternoon. And then just crumpled up on the bed like an old man; frustrated, hurting and weary. I’d expected so much of myself and of England. We’d prepared right. Everything had felt right. And we’d missed maybe the best chance any of us would ever have. It wasn’t as if I needed to sit there and start trying to workout why. Why didn’t matter right now. All that mattered was the plain truth. Even then, a couple of hours after the game, I still couldn’t quite take it in as a fact. The air pressure in that hotel room bore down on my ear drums. For me, for all of us, it was just empty now. There’d be the semis and a final after we got home. We’d be watching on television along with the rest of the planet. But the real thing had slipped away. For us, the World Cup was over. England were out.